CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

QA ENGINEER IN THE AI ERA

The most AI-hit occupation on the index — and a six-figure median. Both facts are the same fact: the job became engineering.

★ TL;DR — YES — but only the automation-first version. BLS median $104,300 (Software QA Analysts and Testers, May 2025), growth ~+6%, and the American Staffing Association's AI Impact Index ranks this occupation #1 of ALL occupations for AI impact. Manual testing as an entry plan is dead; the occupation grows because the job is now writing the test systems. This map is that route, from month one. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$104K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK MEDIUM · CERTIFICATE

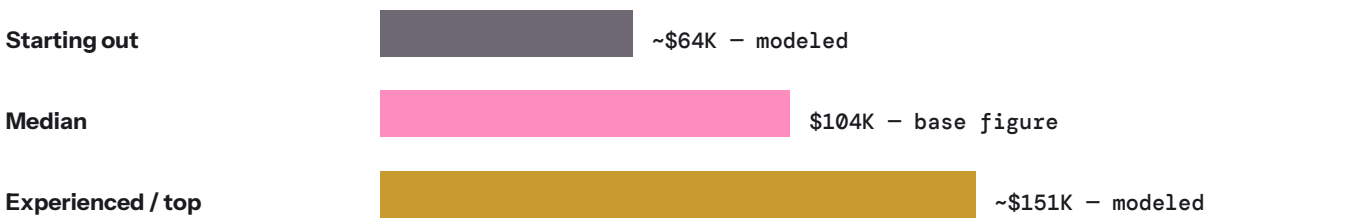
- Works as a start because: the occupation still grows (~+6%, 2025–35; its BLS group with developers grows +10% with ~106,100 openings a year) at a verified $104,300 median — real demand, real openings, real money.

- The catch that decides everything: AI writes and runs the tests now. Entry postings require Selenium/Playwright automation, API testing and AI-tool fluency from day one — several describe the junior job as directing AI test agents and doing exploratory testing.

- The surviving human layer: test design, coverage judgment, evaluating AI-generated code for stability and security, and owning release risk. That is engineering work — which is why the pay went UP as the tasks automated.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for QA Engineer is a ~$104K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A QA ENGINEER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Design test coverage: decide what must be proven before a release ships
- ✓ Write automated test suites in code — frameworks, APIs, CI pipelines
- ✓ Direct AI test agents; validate and harden what they generate
- ✓ Hunt the failures automation misses: exploratory testing and defect judgment

Think: a crash-test engineer, not a crash-test dummy. The dummy's job — repeat the impact, by hand, forever — is the one that ended.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Test execution, test-case generation, script drafting, regression runs, flaky-test churn. The manual tester's entire shift — clicking through the same flows and logging what breaks — is now the machine's default workload.	Deciding what 'broken' means before anyone ships: coverage strategy, risk calls, exploratory instinct, and judging whether AI-generated code and tests are actually trustworthy. Release risk has a name on it, and the name is human.

⚠ **THE MANUAL-TESTING BOOTCAMP TRAP: any course or roadmap selling manual testing as your entry — learn the tools, click the flows, get hired — is selling a dead rung. The ASA index ranks this occupation #1 for AI impact precisely because that layer went first. If the syllabus doesn't have you writing test code in month one, it is training you for the version of this job that no longer hires.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Engineering-adjacent from day one: code, systems, pipelines ✓ Adversarial puzzles: your job is imagining how things break ✓ Remote-friendly with a verified six-figure median at the middle	✗ Not a no-code refuge: the non-coding version of this job is gone ✗ Not low-pressure: the release stops at your signature ✗ Not static: frameworks and AI tooling churn every year

Good fit? Career-switchers willing to code from month one, especially anyone with a break-things instinct and the patience to prove a negative. The door is open — it is just a

programming door now.
Bad fit? Anyone choosing QA specifically to avoid learning to code. That was a real strategy in 2019. The #1 AI-impact ranking is what happened to it.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — THE STANDARD ROUTE: AUTOMATION / SDET TRACK	DOOR B — THE ADJACENT MOVE: DEVELOPER-IN-TEST, ENGINEERING-LEANING
Enter as an automation-first QA and aim at SDET (Software Development Engineer in Test). BLS Software QA Analysts and Testers: median $104,300, ~187,600 employed, growth ~+6% (2025–35). The stack is the application: one language (Python or JavaScript/TypeScript), one framework (Playwright or Selenium), API testing, and CI so your suites run on every change. Senior postings in this track explicitly include evaluating AI-generated code — the growth edge of the occupation. First move: pick the language, automate the login and checkout flows of a public demo shop, and put the repo where a hiring manager can run it.	Come at the same occupation from the engineering side: build a developer's portfolio with a test-engineering spine — your own small app, shipped with a serious automated test suite, CI from the first commit, and a written defect-and-risk log. You apply to the same QA/SDET seats (same BLS occupation, same $104,300 median) plus junior developer roles in test-heavy teams, where the ~106,100 annual openings of the combined developers-and-QA group live. It is slower to first paycheck than Door A and has the higher ceiling: every artifact you produce is also a development portfolio. First move: ship the app ugly but tested — coverage you can defend beats features you can't.

Smart move: Wherever you enter: make your proof runnable. A public repo where a stranger can execute your suite against a real app demonstrates the entire modern job in one click — no certificate argues louder.
Where you land after: You land as the engineer who owns release risk — SDET track, automation lead, or sideways into development with a testing spine most developers never build.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
CODE FROM	MASTER ONE	WIRE IT	ADD THE	BUILD THE	APPLY IN

STEP 1 — Code from month one

SELF-PACED · 3-4 WEEKS

- One language properly: Python or JavaScript/TypeScript — variables to functions to classes
- Testing theory in parallel, one hour a day: equivalence, boundaries, risk-based coverage

STEP 2 — Master one framework deeply

SELF-PACED · 3–4 WEEKS

- Playwright (or Selenium): selectors, waits, assertions, page objects — no drag-and-drop recorders as a crutch
- API testing alongside: requests, status codes, contracts

STEP 3 — Wire it into CI

FREE · 2 WEEKS

- GitHub Actions or equivalent: your suite runs on every push, reports like a professional
- Learn to read failures like an engineer — flaky is a bug in your test, not an excuse

STEP 4 — Add the AI layer, honestly

SELF-PACED · 2 WEEKS

- Use AI test-generation tools the way postings describe: direct them, review output, harden what's weak
- Practice the senior skill early: evaluate AI-generated code for stability and security holes

STEP 5 — Build the runnable proof

FREE · 3–4 WEEKS

- A public repo: full suite against a real demo app, CI green, README that explains your coverage strategy
- Add an exploratory-testing charter and five beautifully documented real defects you found by hand

STEP 6 — Apply in the automation lane only

FREE · ONGOING

- QA automation, SDET-track and developer-in-test postings; skip manual-only listings entirely
- Lead every application with the repo link — let them run your work before they read your résumé

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: pick your language and framework. Delete every manual-testing course tab — that door is closed.
- □ Days 1–30: code daily; testing theory in parallel; first automated flows running locally by day 30.
- □ Days 31–60: framework depth, API testing, CI wired; the public repo takes shape.
- □ Days 61–90: AI-tool layer, exploratory charters, documented defects; apply in the automation lane with the repo as proof.

□ Day 90: you're an automation-first candidate with runnable evidence — in the one version of this occupation that is hiring.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest "probably NOT you". → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **WRITE THE TESTS. OWN THE RELEASE.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.